

STEVENMOLLYSEDT

Travel Radio Australia and this month we're in Amsterdam of course and we're in a very famous place here in Amsterdam called Molly Malone's Irish Pub and I have the owner and manager here, Stephen. Stephen, welcome to the program. Thank you Geoff, happy to be welcome, happy to be part of the show.

Obviously a big hello to all those listening in Australia or wherever you might be in the world. Tell us a bit about your background Stephen, how did you end up here in Amsterdam? Well my dad is actually Dutch, I grew up here then moved to Dublin when I was 19 years old, actually 20 sorry. There for four years, my mum and dad still live over there, my mum's Irish and as always it's a luxury to have two nationalities but it can also be a curse a bit if you will, a blessing and a curse because you're always, well you're either at home in two or you're not at home but I'm loving being in Amsterdam again so if I'm here I miss there and from there I miss here but I'm currently back in Amsterdam now for 19 years.

And this pub, what happened, did you just walk past it or you had some mates over here, the Molly Malone's pub, extremely famous in Amsterdam, probably one of the most oldest buildings in town too? Two, it's a building from 1678 so it is one of the oldest streets of Amsterdam, now it wasn't always an Irish pub, it actually was a warehouse back then for coffee and tea. Molly's itself was founded in 1997 so a good few years before I got back here but the then manager happened to be an old mate of mine from Dublin and he was looking for extra hands to help him out and one thing led to another, I started working here as a bartender and as time progressed more and more responsibilities came and eventually I had the chance to take over. So you're working here as a manager and then the opportunity came I suppose at one point to become the owner? Yeah that opportunity arose a few years back, happy and proud to be able to step into that opening and we've been planning along nicely since, I mean it's a phenomenal bar in terms of course I'm saying this myself but I love the fact that it has the old country kind of Irish vibe with the brick walls and the big wooden oak beams but we of course have the authenticity, we try and keep up with live music, we have live music three four nights a week and of course all the Irish sports we keep up and the international sports so it has that cosy feel in an international kind of place as Amsterdam.

Yeah and looking around you've got these old oak barrels that were formerly a brewery or something? No these are actually former Geneva barrels so now Geneva being the predecessor if you will of gin, gin of course quite known in the British and international world but the British like they did with many things they took things that were good but weren't theirs, similar to Geneva, Geneva was actually a Dutch invention made from the juniper berries and the old seafaring nations kind of took that from the Dutch and gin is kind of derived in its name as well, the whole etymology of it as Geneva. So these are all Geneva barrels, funny enough they fit the decor nicely, most people think they're whiskey barrels but we have to be honest they're not, they do fit

the decor all right but yeah they're old they're about 150 years old just those barrels on their own. Yeah they're really authentic and the place when you walk in it's like walking into a wooden real cosy Irish pub, you could be in Ireland somewhere.

Yeah if you were to close the doors it feels like you're in a country pub somewhere down in the bogs. Now you have a fantastic terrace here and one of my favorite things to do in Amsterdam is just come to the terrace and sit out there and watch these tourist boats go by, it's a really good thing you have out there. That is one of our lucky points in terms of our location, it's the proximity to central station we're right around the corner from the red light area but we're also lucky enough to be right in the canal and it's a pedestrianized canal so we don't have to worry about trams, buses or cars, it pretty much is just pedestrians walking by and the boats passing by in the canal themselves so it's great for people watching.

And now you've just taken over a new place which is right opposite central station called Batavia, tell us about that. That's right it's an opportunity that arose, we weren't really so much on the lookout to expand but sometimes things are very good and when they come you can't say no. Batavia it's an old, it's a monumental building again, it's right across central station, it's over 200 square meters, three floors and again like ourselves there's a lot of wood, a lot of oak, a lot of character and Ford's making that an international base for those coming into the city of course into the station be it from the airport or from an international train they can easily walk into the bar and we'll give them the same welcome and hospitality they have here.

Yeah so it's right across there so if you are coming to central station Amsterdam CS just walk straight across the road you'll see Batavia and Molly Malone's just around the corner. Yeah this is it, I mean once you get out in the station you see this huge steeple of a church, it's the Saint Nicholas church and Batavia is right next to the church and Molly's right at the back of the church so whether you swerve left or right around the church you'll still find us on the canal. Now you've had some interesting visitors over the years I suppose you've had some celebrities pop in and well-known people both from the Netherlands and overseas sometimes.

We do yeah I mean we don't often, I mean Amsterdam itself has its draw for everyone and celebrities the same, we do feel honored enough to have some celebrity guests come in now and again thinking back over recent times we've had Kyle Frampton the former world heavy, no the world featherweight boxing champion we had in and we also had in recent times we had Hanson the guys from the umpire song they were in and we've also this is the last couple of months but you know they're not world stars in that sense but still very proud to have them in. We had the the Mary Wallopers were in only recently an Irish band currently making the waves around the world with kind of a rejuvenation of the Irish traditional music and their own unique spin to it they were in only a couple of weeks ago too. Now how can people find out more about Molly Malone's and Batavia online Stephen? Go to our websites there is for Molly's we have www.mollyinamsterdam.com and for Batavia we have www.batavia1920.com because it's a building from 1920 so that's why the bar is Batavia 1920.

Wonderful well Stephen the general manager and owner of the Molly Malone's Irish pub and Batavia bar here in Amsterdam Central right across the road thanks very much for being with us on Travel Radio Australia hopefully you can come down to Australia one day and hang out with us. I hope so Jeff I hope so it's a fair old travel but if I have the time I'd love to. Thanks very much.